

AFTER

The growth of universities and the scholastic movement led to the humanist and intellectual movements of the Renaissance.

THE RENAISSANCE

The rediscovery of ancient Greek and Latin texts during the later medieval period stimulated interest in classical learning and led to the great **artistic and cultural flowering** of the 15th- and 16th-century Renaissance 250–53 >>



PICO DELLA MIRANDOLA

HUMANISM

The key intellectual movement of the Renaissance, humanism emphasized **human reason and dignity** rather than the Christian humility and obedience to authority that had been the focus of the medieval Church. The Italian writer **Pico della Mirandola** captured the new spirit in 1489 with his *Oration on the Dignity of Man*, a preface to 900 theses on religion and philosophy. Renaissance humanists, schooled in Greek and Latin from an early age and often learning Hebrew and Arabic as well, studied the poetry, grammar, rhetoric, and ethics of the classical authors in their original languages.

The Lindisfarne Gospel

Created by the monks of Lindisfarne in northern England in the 8th century, this illuminated Latin text is a striking example of early medieval religious art and scholarship. An Old English translation was added in the 10th century—the oldest surviving version of the Gospels in English.

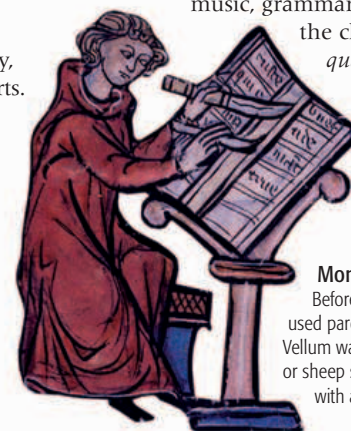
themselves. In Paris, where the main subject was theology, the Church controlled the payment of staff. It took six years to earn a bachelor of arts degree, and a further 12 years for a master's degree and doctorate.

By the 14th century, universities had become central to intellectual life. Theology remained the most prestigious area of study, and all students were at least in minor orders (the lower ranks of the clergy). However, the first six years of study now focused on the seven liberal arts: arithmetic, geometry, astronomy, music, grammar, logic, and rhetoric—the classical *trivium* and

quadrivium. In this way, the universities signaled a move away from an intellectual world entirely dominated by the Church.

Monastic scribe

Before paper became common, scribes used parchment or vellum for their work. Vellum was created by scraping down calf or sheep skins and smoothing the surface with a pumice stone or chalk.



Toledo translation school

Alfonso X "the Wise" of Castile in Spain was patron of a flourishing court of scholars who translated Arabic works on subjects ranging from astronomy to chess.

these authorities to the problems of Christian theology. Thomas Aquinas's *Summa Theologica*, for example, is a masterful synthesis of Aristotle's philosophy and Christian tradition (see p.195).

and Aristotle were important for the followers of the movement, as they provided the basic tools for constructing arguments. But so were Christian authorities such as St. Augustine and, above all, the Bible. The scholastic method sought to apply the learning of

The universities

A better understanding of the classical art of debate, combined with a growing demand for education, led to the

foundation of the first universities in the 12th–13th centuries. Medieval universities evolved from earlier cathedral schools and monasteries, and were created to study theology, law, medicine, and the arts.

Most universities did not have a central campus—classes were taught at masters' homes or in churches. In a university such as Bologna in northern Italy, where law was the most popular subject, students hired and paid the lecturers